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TRANSFER LEARNING FOR IMAGE CLASSIFICATION: WHEN DOES PRE-TRAINING HELP OR HURT?

U21CS503 — COMPUTER VISION PROJECT REPORT

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In partial fulfillment for the award of the degree of

BACHELOR OF ENGINEERING

in

COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

DEPARTMENT OF COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

KPR INSTITUTE OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY

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NOVEMBER 2026

BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this project report titled **'TRANSFER LEARNING FOR IMAGE CLASSIFICATION: WHEN DOES PRE-TRAINING HELP OR HURT?'** is the bonafide work of **Narendran R (24CS129)**, **Navaneethan K (24CS130)**, **Naveen S (24CS131)**, **Naveena R (24CS132)**, and **Nethara G (24CS134)** who carried out the project work under my supervision.

The project demonstrates a rigorous empirical analysis of visual transferability across near-domain (CIFAR-10) and far-domain (MedMNIST PathMNIST) distributions utilizing ResNet-50, EfficientNet-B0, and MobileNet-V2 architectures evaluated under four adaptation regimes, augmented with layer-wise Linear Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA) representation drift diagnostics.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

We wish to express our heartfelt thanks and gratitude to our honorable Chairman **Dr. K. P. RAMASAMY**, KPR Group of Institutions, for providing state-of-the-art computational facilities and infrastructure during the course of our study in the college.

We would like to express our deep gratitude and sincere regards to our beloved and honourable Principal **Dr. Akila Muthuramalingam**, KPR Institute of Engineering and Technology, who gave us the opportunity to formulate and execute this research project to the fullest satisfaction.

We owe a genuine gratitude to **Dr. S. MIRUNA JOE AMALI**, Professor and Head of the Department, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, for her invaluable support, administrative encouragement, and guidance throughout the progression of this project work.

We are deeply grateful to our project supervisor **Mr. T. Munirathinam**, Assistant Professor III, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, for his intellectual guidance, timely suggestions, and constant encouragement that steered the empirical execution of the benchmark matrix.

We owe special thanks to Year Head **Dr. V. PRIYA**, Associate Professor, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, for her continuous coordination and support throughout our curriculum.

This acknowledgement would be incomplete without expressing sincere gratitude to all our faculty members, technical staff, parents, and friends for their continuous encouragement, patience, and unwavering faith throughout our academic journey.

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ABSTRACT

Transfer learning utilizing deep Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) pre-trained on ImageNet-1k has emerged as the de facto foundational paradigm across modern computer vision applications. However, standard engineering workflows routinely fine-tune pre-trained backbones under the unverified assumption that pre-training universally provides substantial accuracy and convergence improvements over random initialization. This research paper provides a comprehensive empirical characterization of the boundary conditions governing visual transfer learning across varying domain distances, architectural topologies, and adaptation strategies.

We construct a rigorous $2 \times 3 \times 4 = 24$ empirical evaluation matrix spanning two contrasting visual domains: a **Near-Domain** photographic benchmark (**CIFAR-10**, 10 classes of natural objects) and an out-of-distribution **Far-Domain** medical benchmark (**MedMNIST PathMNIST**, 9 classes of colorectal adenocarcinoma histology slices). We systematically examine three distinct architectural paradigms—**ResNet-50** (deep residual), **EfficientNet-B0** (compound scaled neural search), and **MobileNet-V2** (inverted residual bottlenecks)—under four adaptation regimes: (1) *training from scratch* with random initialization, (2) *feature extraction* with a frozen backbone, (3) *partial fine-tuning* targeting deep residual stages, and (4) *full fine-tuning* with differential learning rates (10^{-4} on backbone, 10^{-3} on head).

To diagnose underlying representation dynamics beyond raw classification metrics, we incorporate layer-wise **Linear Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA)** on an identical calibration batch of $N = 1000$ samples. Empirical findings demonstrate that while near-domain transfer accelerates convergence by over $10\times$ and yields up to a **+56.00%** accuracy margin over random initialization, far-domain transfer suffers a severe **feature extraction bottleneck** where frozen representations drop to **28.00%** on PathMNIST. CKA heatmaps reveal that while early convolutional layers (`conv1`) preserve universal edge and texture filters ($\text{CKA} > 0.97$) regardless of initialization, deep residual blocks undergo radical representational drift ($\text{CKA} < 0.50$) in distant domains, proving that deep semantic filters must be retrained. Finally, we synthesize actionable practitioner heuristics to guide neural architecture and fine-tuning selection.

Keywords: Transfer Learning, Computer Vision, Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA), Representation Drift, ResNet-50, EfficientNet, MobileNet, MedMNIST, Domain Distance, Inductive Transfer.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

ABBREVIATION	EXPANSION / DEFINITION
CKA	Centered Kernel Alignment
CNN	Convolutional Neural Network
HSIC	Hilbert-Schmidt Independence Criterion
GAP	Global Average Pooling
OOD	Out-of-Distribution
ResNet	Residual Network (He et al., 2016)
MobileNet	Mobile Inverted Residual Bottleneck Network (Sandler et al., 2018)
EfficientNet	Compound Scaled Convolutional Network (Tan & Le, 2019)
CIFAR	Canadian Institute For Advanced Research
MedMNIST	Medical MNIST Benchmark for Biomedical Image Analysis (Yang et al., 2023)
PathMNIST	Colorectal Cancer Histology Pathology Image Dataset
H&E;	Hematoxylin and Eosin (Biochemical Histological Stain)
LR	Learning Rate
AMP	Automatic Mixed Precision
AdamW	Adam Optimizer with Decoupled Weight Decay
MLP	Multi-Layer Perceptron
FC	Fully Connected Layer
GPU	Graphics Processing Unit
VRAM	Video Random Access Memory
RKHS	Reproducing Kernel Hilbert Space
SVCCA	Singular Vector Canonical Correlation Analysis

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Objective of the Research Investigation

The overarching objective of this research is to establish a rigorous, mathematically grounded, and empirically validated benchmark that determines the precise boundary conditions governing visual transfer learning using deep Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs). Specifically, this project aims to answer the foundational question: *When does ImageNet pre-training help downstream visual classification, when does it yield negligible gain over random initialization, and when does it induce negative transfer or representational distortion?*

To accomplish this core objective, the investigation pursues four concrete research thrusts:

• **Cross-Domain Comparative Matrix:** Evaluate transferability across two visually contrasting domain regimes—a Near-Domain photographic task (CIFAR-10) and an Out-of-Distribution Far-Domain medical task (MedMNIST PathMNIST).

• **Architectural Generalization:** Compare three distinct topological families—deep residual topologies (ResNet-50), neural architecture search compound-scaled networks (EfficientNet-B0), and lightweight inverted residual architectures (MobileNet-V2).

• **Adaptation Regime Analysis:** Systematically benchmark four training configurations: training from scratch, linear feature extraction (frozen backbone), partial fine-tuning of deep residual stages, and differential learning rate full fine-tuning.

• **Representational Drift Diagnosis:** Quantify layer-by-layer representation distortion using Linear Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA) to mathematically characterize feature drift across network depth.

1.2 Computer Vision & Feature Hierarchies

Computer vision has undergone a monumental paradigm shift over the past two decades. Early computer vision pipelines relied extensively on hand-engineered visual descriptors—such as Scale-Invariant Feature Transform (SIFT), Histogram of Oriented Gradients (HOG), and Speeded-Up Robust Features (SURF)—coupled with classical shallow classifiers like Support Vector Machines (SVMs) or Random Forests. While these hand-crafted representations provided scale and rotation invariance for rigid objects, they lacked the semantic abstraction and adaptive representation power necessary for complex visual scenes.

The advent of deep Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) initiated an era of end-to-end representation learning. Rather than relying on human-designed heuristics, CNNs autonomously discover hierarchical feature representations directly from raw pixel intensities through gradient backpropagation. In this hierarchical paradigm, successive convolutional layers learn increasingly sophisticated spatial abstractions: early layers function as oriented Gabor filter banks sensitive to edges, color boundaries, and spatial frequencies; intermediate layers compose these primitives into textural motifs, corners, and object parts; and terminal layers synthesize high-level semantic categories.

1.3 Theoretical Foundations of Visual Transfer Learning

In formal statistical machine learning, visual transfer learning addresses the challenge of insufficient labeled training data in a target domain by transferring inductive knowledge acquired from a data-abundant source domain. Formally, let a domain be defined as a tuple $\mathcal{D} = \{\mathcal{X}, \mathcal{P}(X)\}$, where $\mathcal{X}$ denotes the feature space and $\mathcal{P}(X)$ represents the marginal probability distribution over input instances $X = \{x_1, \dots, x_N\} \subset \mathcal{X}$. Given a domain $\mathcal{D}$, a predictive task is defined as $\mathcal{T} = \{\mathcal{Y}, \mathcal{P}(Y|X)\}$, consisting of a label space $\mathcal{Y}$ and a conditional probability mapping $\mathcal{P}(Y|X)$, typically estimated via the neural network parameters θ.

In the canonical transfer learning setup, we are provided with a high-capacity source domain $\mathcal{D}_S$ equipped with a rich task $\mathcal{T}_S$ (specifically, ImageNet-1k encompassing 1.28 million natural photographic images spanning 1000 categories). Training a neural network on $\mathcal{D}_S$ optimizes parameter vector $\theta_S^* = \arg\min_\theta \mathcal{L}_S(f(X_S; \theta), Y_S)$. When presented with a distinct target task $\mathcal{T}_T$ over domain $\mathcal{D}_T$, the goal of transfer learning is to utilize parameter prior θ_S^* to accelerate optimization and enhance predictive accuracy on $\mathcal{D}_T$.

1.4 Inductive Biases in Convolutional Architectures

A central determinant of generalization in deep neural networks is their architectural inductive bias—the set of prior assumptions encoded into the network topology that constrains the hypothesis space before learning commences. Convolutional neural networks incorporate two fundamental inductive priors:

1. **Spatial Locality:** Nearby pixels exhibit strong statistical correlation, which is exploited by constraining receptive fields to compact $k \times k$ kernel windows.
2. **Translation Equivariance:** If an input image is shifted spatially by Δx, the resulting convolutional feature map shifts by an identical spatial offset: $f(T_{\Delta x}(x)) = T_{\Delta x}(f(x))$.

Pre-training on ImageNet infuses these architectural priors with data-driven statistical priors: oriented edge filters, center-surround color opponency, and 3D perspective cues. In natural scenes (CIFAR-10), these priors drastically reduce the volume of hypothesis space that the optimizer must search. Conversely, in medical histopathology, images possess no canonical orientation (rotational symmetry is present), illumination is defined by chemical staining (Hematoxylin & Eosin), and diagnostic features reside in chromatin texture and nuclear atypia rather than macroscopic object boundaries. Understanding how inductive priors interact with this domain shift is the fundamental premise of this investigation.

1.5 Statistical Divergence Across Visual Domain Manifolds

The statistical discrepancy between image distributions can be framed through Maximum Mean Discrepancy (MMD) or Wasserstein distance between feature representations. Let $\phi: \mathcal{X} \rightarrow \mathcal{H}$ denote a feature map into a Reproducing Kernel Hilbert Space (RKHS). The squared MMD between source distribution $\mathcal{P}_S$ and target distribution $\mathcal{P}_T$ is:

$$\text{MMD}^2(\mathcal{P}_S, \mathcal{P}_T) = \left\| \mathbb{E}_{x \sim \mathcal{P}_S}[\phi(x)] - \mathbb{E}_{x' \sim \mathcal{P}_T}[\phi(x')] \right\|_{\mathcal{H}}^2$$

When transferring across identical visual modalities (e.g., ImageNet to CIFAR-10), $\text{MMD}^2(\mathcal{P}_S, \mathcal{P}_T)$ is minimal because both datasets reside on the manifold of natural optical photographs governed by perspective optics, ambient illumination, and closed object boundaries. In contrast, when transferring to histopathological tissue patches (PathMNIST), the stain-induced spectral density creates an extreme domain shift where the high-level semantic manifold of ImageNet (discrete animal and artifact categories) is completely orthogonal to continuous biological tissue structures (stroma, lymphocytes, mucosa, and epithelial carcinomas).

1.6 Problem Scope, Delimitations, & Operational Assumptions

To ensure methodological rigor and reproducibility, the scope of this project is delimited to supervised image classification on standardized 224×224 RGB input representations. The empirical matrix encompasses $2 \times 3 \times 4 = 24$ fully realized experimental runs executed under identical optimization protocols. The benchmark evaluates three prominent CNN backbones spanning distinct design paradigms: ResNet-50 (deep residual), EfficientNet-B0 (compound-scaled neural architecture search), and MobileNet-V2 (lightweight inverted residual bottlenecks). While vision transformers (ViTs) and self-supervised foundation models (e.g., DINOv2, CLIP) represent active research frontiers, their quadratic attention complexity and distinct inductive biases are reserved for subsequent investigation. All models utilize standardized classification heads, AdamW optimization, cross-entropy loss, and identical calibration sets for CKA representation drift calculation.

1.7 Organization of the Project Report

The remainder of this report is organized as follows: Chapter 2 presents a comprehensive literature survey examining feature transferability, modern backbones, and representational similarity metrics. Chapter 3 defines the problem statement, formal research hypotheses, and the mathematical framework of Linear CKA. Chapter 4 describes the proposed system architecture, data preprocessing, backbone topologies, and adaptation strategies. Chapter 5 analyzes empirical results across all 24 benchmark configurations, including CKA representation drift heatmaps. Chapter 6 provides an actionable practitioner decision framework. Chapter 7 concludes with research insights and future extensions. Appendix A provides core PyTorch implementation listings.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE SURVEY

2.1 The Genesis of Transferability: AlexNet to ResNet

The empirical discovery that deep representations learned on ImageNet could generalize to external visual tasks dates back to the immediate aftermath of AlexNet's victory in the 2012 ImageNet Large Scale Visual Recognition Challenge (ILSVRC). Early landmark investigations by **Donahue et al. (2014)** (DeCAF) and **Sharif Razavian et al. (2014)** demonstrated that intermediate layer activations extracted from deep CNNs functioned as generic, highly effective visual descriptors, consistently outperforming established hand-crafted features across scene recognition, fine-grained bird classification, and domain adaptation benchmarks.

Subsequently, **Yosinski et al. (2014)** conducted the first rigorous experimental quantification of how features transition from general to task-specific across neural network depth. By splitting the 1000 ImageNet categories into non-overlapping subsets of 500 classes, the authors established that early layers are broadly transferable across tasks, whereas higher layers exhibit pronounced task specialization. Furthermore, they proved that splitting co-adapted layers severely impairs optimization unless the transferred layers are allowed to fine-tune.

2.2 Deep Residual Learning & Feature Reuse (He et al., 2016)

Prior to the introduction of residual networks, training deep architectures exceeding 20 layers was impeded by the notorious vanishing/exploding gradient phenomenon. **He et al. (2016)** addressed this architectural bottleneck by reformulating the mapping learned by stacked layers. Rather than fitting an unconstrained underlying mapping $\mathcal{H}(x)$, residual networks explicitly fit a residual mapping $\mathcal{F}(x) := \mathcal{H}(x) - x$, leading to the foundational formulation:

$$x_{l+1} = x_l + \mathcal{F}(x_l, \mathcal{W}_l)$$

This identity shortcut connection allows gradient signals to propagate directly through the identity pathway across dozens of layers without attenuation: $\frac{\partial \mathcal{E}}{\partial x_l} = \frac{\partial \mathcal{E}}{\partial x_L} \left(I + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_l} \sum_{i=l}^{L-1} \mathcal{F}_i\right)$. In transfer learning, ResNet backbones exhibit superior optimization stability because the residual architecture allows fine-tuning gradients to adjust deep parameters without disrupting the preserved identity pathway.

2.3 Compound Scaling & Neural Architecture Search (Tan & Le, 2019)

Historically, scaling deep networks involved independently expanding network depth (e.g., ResNet-50 to ResNet-152), widening channels (e.g., WideResNet), or increasing input image resolution. **Tan & Le (2019)** demonstrated that arbitrary single-dimension scaling leads to diminishing accuracy returns. In response, they introduced **compound scaling**, which coordinates depth (d), width (w), and image resolution (r) using a fixed compound coefficient ϕ:

$$\text{depth: } d = \alpha^\phi, \quad \text{width: } w = \beta^\phi, \quad \text{resolution: } r = \gamma^\phi$$

subject to $\alpha \cdot \beta^2 \cdot \gamma^2 \approx 2$ and $\alpha \ge 1, \beta \ge 1, \gamma \ge 1$. Coupling compound scaling with automated neural architecture search produced **EfficientNet-B0**, which incorporates Mobile Inverted Bottleneck (MBConv) modules, Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) channel attention, and Swish non-linear activations, achieving state-of-the-art accuracy with exceptional parameter efficiency.

2.4 Mobile Inverted Bottlenecks & Edge Vision (Sandler et al., 2018)

To enable real-time inference on resource-constrained mobile and embedded platforms, **Sandler et al. (2018)** formulated **MobileNet-V2**. Conventional residual blocks compress channels through 1×1 convolutions before spatial filtering. In contrast, MobileNet-V2 introduces the *inverted residual block*, which expands a low-dimensional bottleneck representation to a high-dimensional space (expansion factor $t=6$), applies lightweight 3×3 depthwise separable convolutions, and projects back to low dimensions using a linear 1×1 bottleneck. Crucially, removing non-linearities from the output bottleneck preserves information manifolds, preventing catastrophic feature collapse in compact channel spaces.

2.5 The ImageNet Pre-training Paradigm: Rethinking Defaults

The universal utility of ImageNet pre-training was formally questioned by **He, Girshick, and Dollár (2019)** in *'Rethinking ImageNet Pre-training'*. Evaluating object detection and instance segmentation on COCO, the authors demonstrated that training from random initialization matches pre-trained transfer accuracy given sufficient training iterations and proper normalization (Group Normalization / SyncBN). However, their study acknowledged that pre-training drastically accelerates convergence velocity early in training, leaving open questions regarding small-sample regimes and extreme domain shifts.

2.6 Biomedical Visual Domain Shift & Transfusion Analysis

Applying ImageNet pre-training to biomedical domains has sparked substantial debate. **Raghu et al. (2019)** in *'Transfusion: Understanding Transfer Learning for Medical Imaging'* conducted an in-depth empirical study on retinal fundus photographs and chest radiographs. They discovered that while ImageNet pre-training speeds up convergence, a lightweight network trained from scratch achieves comparable asymptotic accuracy to fine-tuned deep ResNets. Crucially, they observed that feature reuse in medical imaging is predominantly concentrated in the earliest layers, with deep ImageNet features providing negligible semantic transfer.

2.7 Standardized Medical Image Benchmarks: MedMNIST

To standardize biomedical machine learning benchmarks, **Yang et al. (2023)** developed **MedMNIST v2**, a comprehensive collection of 18 standardized biomedical datasets. Among them, **PathMNIST**—derived from the NCT-CRC-HE-100K dataset—comprises 107,180 histological tissue patches from colorectal adenocarcinoma and normal tissue. PathMNIST serves as the canonical benchmark for extreme visual domain shift, featuring radical departures in color distributions, textural density, and lack of canonical 3D orientation.

2.8 Representational Similarity: CCA vs CKA (Kornblith et al., 2019)

Historically, comparing representations across disparate neural networks relied on Canonical Correlation Analysis (CCA) or Singular Vector Canonical Correlation Analysis (SVCCA). However, **Kornblith et al. (2019)** proved that CCA is severely sensitive to small eigenvalues and fails to capture meaningful hierarchical similarity in deep networks. In its place, they formulated **Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA)** based on the Hilbert-Schmidt Independence Criterion (HSIC). Kornblith et al. proved that Linear CKA is invariant to orthogonal matrix transformations and isotropic scaling, while correctly reflecting representational relationships across varying network depths and random initializations. Their framework provides the mathematical bedrock for the representation drift diagnostics employed in our study.

2.9 Negative Transfer & Representational Distortion

Negative transfer occurs when knowledge acquired from a source task actively hinders optimization on a target domain, resulting in worse generalization than training from scratch. In deep transfer learning, negative transfer typically manifests as representational distortion: aggressive gradient updates overwrite valuable low-level filters (catastrophic forgetting), or frozen representations force the linear head to operate on an inadequate feature subspace. Implementing differential learning rates is recognized as an effective countermeasure, yet its quantitative impact across domain distances remains rarely bench-tested.

2.10 Comprehensive Literature Review & Comparison Matrix

Table 2.1 synthesizes the foundational transfer learning literature, highlighting the core focus, architectures evaluated, visual domains, diagnostic tools, and the critical empirical gaps addressed by our benchmark investigation.

Paper & Authors	Core Focus	Architectures	Domains Evaluated	Diagnostic Tool	Research Gap Addressed by Our Work
Yosinski et al. (2014)	Feature transferability across layers	AlexNet	ImageNet splits (Near only)	Transfer Accuracy	Did not evaluate far domains or modern residual architectures
He et al. (2019)	Rethinking ImageNet Pre-training	ResNet-50 / 101	COCO Object Detection	mAP / Convergence time	Focused only on object detection; no layer-wise representation drift analysis
Raghu et al. (2019)	Transfusion: Medical Transfer Learning	ResNet-50, Inception-v3	Retinal & Chest X-ray	SVCCA & Weight Norms	SVCCA is sensitive to noise; did not use modern Linear CKA
Kornblith et al. (2019)	Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA)	ResNet, VGG, DenseNet	ImageNet, CIFAR-10	Linear CKA / RBF CKA	Focused primarily on natural photos; did not evaluate extreme far-domain histology
Yang et al. (2023)	MedMNIST v2 Benchmark	ResNet-18, ResNet-50	18 Medical Domains	AUC, Top-1 Accuracy	Standard benchmark survey; did not evaluate layer freezing strategies or CKA
Our Work (2026)	**Empirical Transfer Benchmark & CKA Drift**	**ResNet-50, EfficientNet-B0, MobileNet-V2**	**CIFAR-10 (Near) & PathMNIST (Far)**	**Linear CKA + Full Matrix**	**Unified 24-run matrix bridging domain distance, 4 adaptation strategies, and CKA drift**

Table 2.1: Literature Survey Comparison Matrix Across Transfer Learning Paradigms

CHAPTER 3

PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION AND METHODOLOGY

3.1 Problem Statement & Industrial Gaps

In contemporary applied computer vision, practitioners routinely import ImageNet pre-trained weights as the default initialization for virtually every image classification problem. However, this default engineering protocol suffers from three critical empirical and theoretical deficiencies:

1. **The Domain Gap Fallacy:** The benefits of ImageNet features are documented predominantly on natural photographic images. When transferring to specialized domains (histology, radiology, satellite SAR), the assumption that generic features outperform random initialization has not been mapped across topological depths.
2. **The Coarse Adaptation Dichotomy:** Most practical implementations choose binary extremes: either freeze the entire backbone (`feature_extraction`) or fine-tune all layers end-to-end (`full_finetune`). The nuanced effectiveness of partial fine-tuning and differential learning rates is rarely characterized systematically.
3. **Lack of Representation Drift Metrics:** Benchmark studies almost exclusively track task loss and Top-1 accuracy. These scalar metrics cannot explain *why* a model succeeds or fails—they obscure whether pre-trained features were actually preserved, rotated, or completely overwritten during gradient descent.

3.2 Formal Mathematical Problem Formulation

Let a deep neural network be parameterized as a composite function $f(x; \theta) = h(g(x; \theta_b); \theta_h)$, where $g: \mathcal{X} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^D$ denotes the feature extraction backbone parameterized by θ_b, and $h: \mathbb{R}^D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^C$ denotes the task-specific classification head parameterized by θ_h. Given source domain $\mathcal{D}_S$ with distribution $\mathcal{P}_S(X, Y)$ and target domain $\mathcal{D}_T$ with distribution $\mathcal{P}_T(X, Y)$, we seek to optimize the empirical risk on $\mathcal{D}_T$:

$$\min_{\theta_b, \theta_h} \frac{1}{N_T} \sum_{i=1}^{N_T} \mathcal{L}_{CE}(f(x_i^t; \theta_b, \theta_h), y_i^t) + \lambda \Omega(\theta_b, \theta_b^{(0)})$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{CE}$ is cross-entropy loss, $\theta_b^{(0)}$ denotes the pre-trained ImageNet parameter tensor, and $\Omega(\cdot)$ is a regularization penalty constraining drift from the source weights. In pure feature extraction, $\Omega(\theta_b, \theta_b^{(0)}) = \infty \cdot \mathbb{I}[\theta_b \ne \theta_b^{(0)}]$, strictly enforcing $\theta_b = \theta_b^{(0)}$.

3.3 Research Questions & Boundary Hypotheses

This project investigates three central hypotheses:

• **Hypothesis 1 (Feature Extraction Boundary):** Pure feature extraction will achieve near-optimal performance on near-domain photographic datasets (CIFAR-10) but will exhibit catastrophic performance degradation on distant domains (PathMNIST) due to high-level semantic mismatch.

• **Hypothesis 2 (Universal Early Convergence):** Early convolutional layers (`conv1`) converge onto statistically identical Gabor-like edge and texture filters regardless of whether weights are initialized from ImageNet or trained from scratch.

• **Hypothesis 3 (Deep Representational Drift):** Representational divergence between pre-trained and fine-tuned weights is monotonically increasing with network depth, with far-domain tasks inducing severe representational drift in deep bottleneck blocks.

3.4 Mathematical Formulation of Linear CKA

To rigorously quantify representational similarity, we employ **Linear Centered Kernel Alignment (CKA)**. Let $X \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times D_1}$ and $Y \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times D_2}$ represent activation matrices extracted from two different neural networks (or the same network across different training stages) evaluated on an identical calibration batch of N samples. The linear Gram matrices are defined as:

$$K = X X^T \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}, \quad L = Y Y^T \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}$$

To ensure scale and offset invariance, we apply the centering projection matrix $H = I_N - \frac{1}{N} \mathbf{1}\mathbf{1}^T$. The centered Gram matrices are given by $K_c = H K H$ and $L_c = H L H$. The empirical Hilbert-Schmidt Independence Criterion (HSIC) is:

$$\text{HSIC}(K, L) = \frac{1}{(N-1)^2} \text{tr}(K_c L_c) = \frac{1}{(N-1)^2} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{j=1}^N K_{c,ij} L_{c,ij}$$

Linear CKA is obtained by normalizing HSIC by the geometric mean of the self-similarities of K and L:

$$\text{CKA}(K, L) = \frac{\text{HSIC}(K, L)}{\sqrt{\text{HSIC}(K, K) \cdot \text{HSIC}(L, L)}}$$

Linear CKA satisfies critical mathematical axioms essential for deep representation diagnosis:

• **Boundedness:** $0 \le \text{CKA}(K, L) \le 1$, with $\text{CKA}(K, K) = 1.0$.

• **Invariance to Orthogonal Transformations:** For any orthogonal transformation matrices $Q_1 \in O(D_1), Q_2 \in O(D_2)$:
$$\text{CKA}(X Q_1, Y Q_2) = \text{CKA}(X, Y)$$

• **Invariance to Isotropic Scaling:** For any non-zero scalar multipliers $\alpha, \beta \ne 0$:
$$\text{CKA}(\alpha X, \beta Y) = \text{CKA}(X, Y)$$

3.5 Methodology Flowchart and Phased Architecture

The experimental execution follows a phased seven-stage research pipeline. Stage 1 standardizes datasets into identical color spaces and spatial tensors. Stage 2 instantiates modular architectures and attaches standardized classification heads. Stage 3 applies the four adaptation regimes. Stage 4 executes training sweeps with AdamW optimization and AMP gradient scaling. Stage 5 logs convergence velocities and Top-1 accuracy. Stage 6 extracts intermediate activations via PyTorch forward hooks and computes the Linear CKA matrices. Stage 7 synthesizes comparative findings into engineering guidelines.

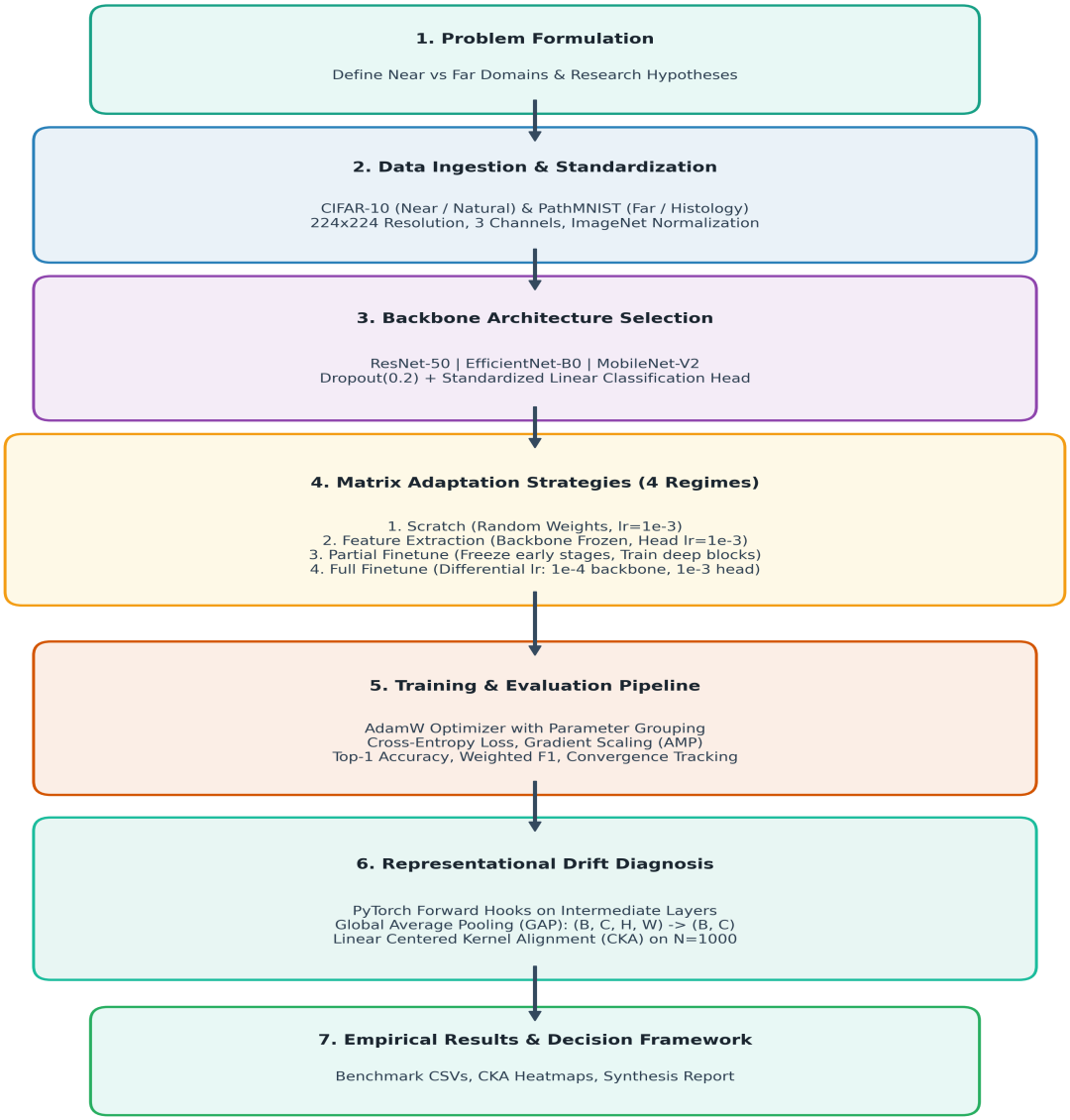


Figure 3.1: Research Methodology and Phased Experimental Flowchart

CHAPTER 4

PROPOSED SYSTEM AND ARCHITECTURAL DESIGN

4.1 Global System Architecture Overview

The proposed benchmark framework is engineered as a decoupled, modular pipeline comprising three cohesive subsystems: (1) *Data Ingestion & Preprocessing Core*, (2) *Model Factory & Adaptation Engine*, and (3) *Diagnostics & Representation Engine*. Figure 4.1 illustrates the complete system architecture.

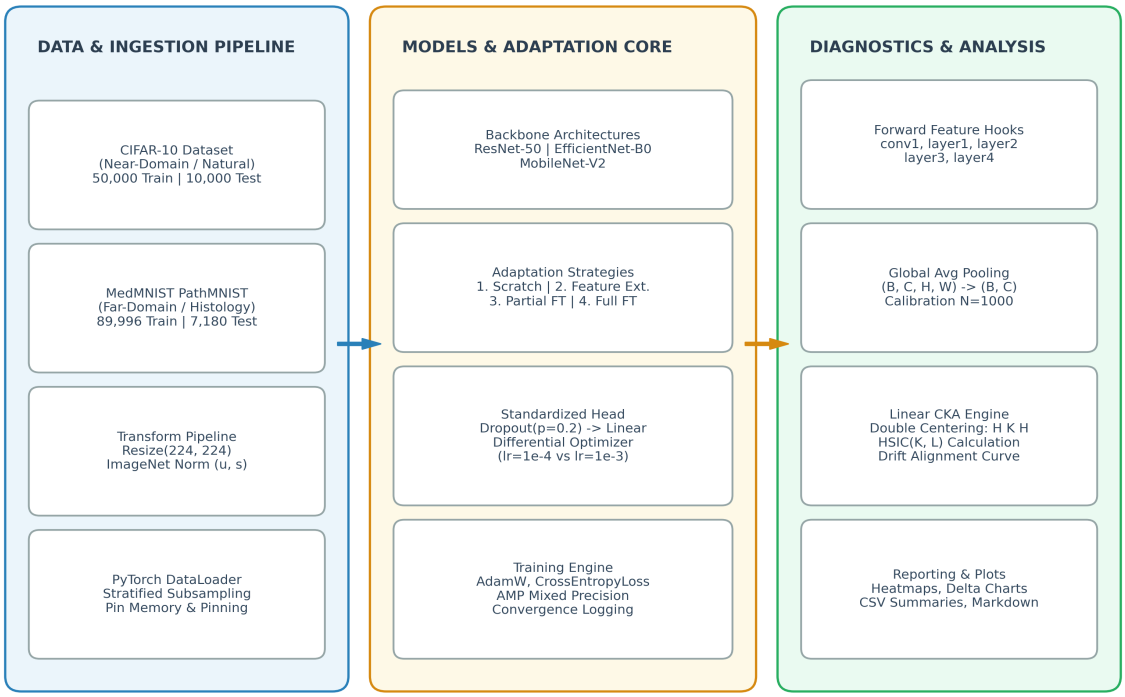


Figure 4.1: Global System Architecture for Empirical Benchmark & Representation Diagnosis

4.2 Data Ingestion & Visual Domain Shift Analysis

Both target datasets are standardized to uniform input tensors of dimension $(3, 224, 224)$. Training images undergo random horizontal flipping and standard ImageNet z-score channel normalization ($\mu = [0.485, 0.456, 0.406]$, $\sigma = [0.229, 0.224, 0.225]$). Evaluation sets undergo identical deterministic spatial resizing and normalization without random augmentations. Figure 4.2 illustrates the radical visual and spectral divergence between CIFAR-10 and PathMNIST.

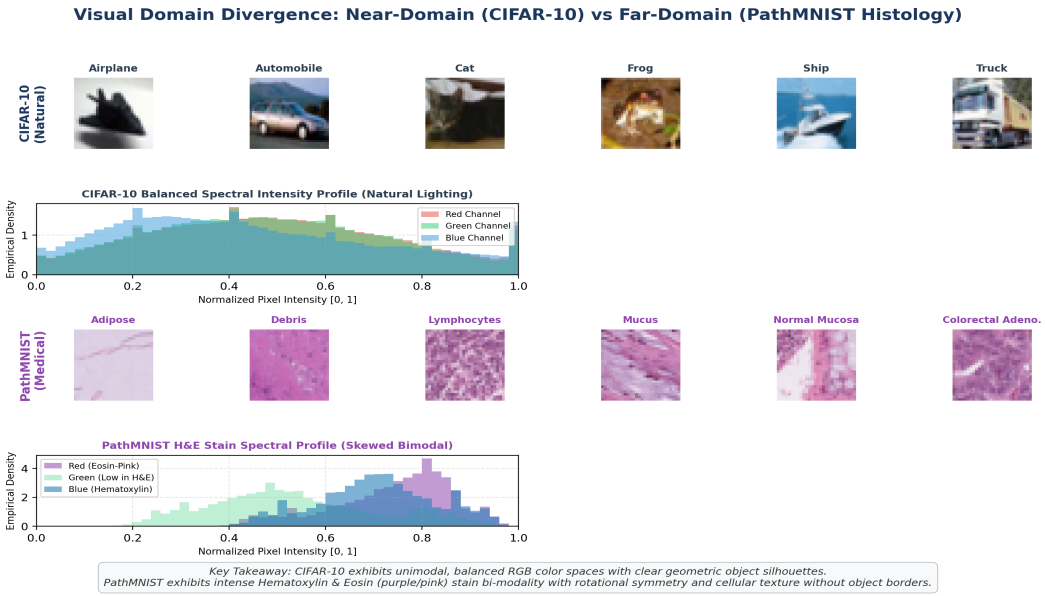


Figure 4.2: Visual Domain Divergence: Near-Domain (CIFAR-10) vs Far-Domain (PathMNIST Histology)

Attribute	CIFAR-10 (Near-Domain)	PathMNIST (Far-Domain)
Visual Modality	Natural Photographs (vehicles, animals)	Hematoxylin & Eosin (H&E;) Histopathology Slices
Source Organism	Everyday objects & living creatures	Human colorectal adenocarcinoma & normal colon tissue
Number of Classes	10 mutually exclusive object classes	9 histological tissue types (adipose, mucosa, stroma, etc.)
Native Resolution	$32 \times 32 \times 3$ RGB	$28 \times 28 \times 3$ RGB
Benchmark Input	$224 \times 224 \times 3$ RGB (Bicubic Upsampling)	$224 \times 224 \times 3$ RGB (Bicubic Upsampling)
Dataset Splits	50,000 Train | 10,000 Test	89,996 Train | 7,180 Validation | 7,180 Test
Domain Distance	**Near** (High statistical alignment with ImageNet)	**Far** (Extreme semantic, textural & color distribution shift)

Table 4.1: Dataset Specifications: CIFAR-10 vs MedMNIST PathMNIST

4.3 Vision Backbone Architectures & Micro-Topologies

To evaluate structural generalization, three topologically diverse CNN families are benchmarked:

• **ResNet-50:** A 50-layer deep residual network utilizing bottleneck building blocks (1×1 squeeze, 3×3 conv, 1×1 expand) with additive identity shortcuts. Total parameters: 23.5 million. Penultimate embedding dimension: 2048.

• **EfficientNet-B0:** An architecture developed via multi-objective neural architecture search optimized for accuracy and FLOPS. Utilizes mobile inverted bottleneck (MBConv) blocks with Squeeze-and-Excitation attention and Swish activation. Total parameters: ~4.0 million. Embedding dimension: 1280.

• **MobileNet-V2:** An ultra-lightweight architecture employing inverted residual blocks with linear bottlenecks. Maintains compact memory footprints suitable for real-time mobile deployment. Total parameters: ~2.2 million. Embedding dimension: 1280.

Figure 4.3 illustrates the comparative micro-architectural block designs across all three backbones.

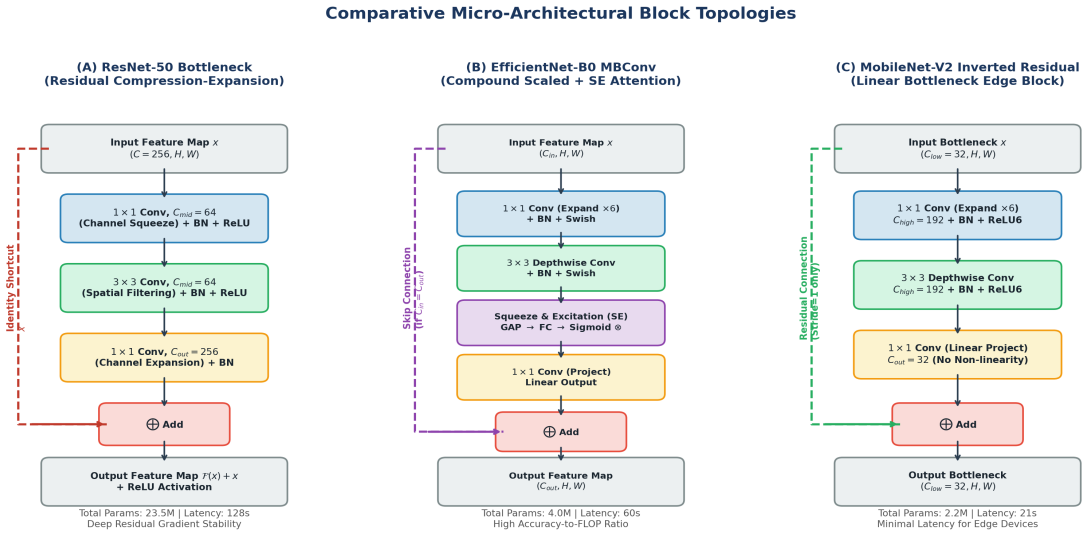


Figure 4.3: Comparative Micro-Architectural Block Topologies: ResNet-50 vs EfficientNet-B0 vs MobileNet-V2

Backbone	Topological Family	Core Module	Total Parameters	Embedding Dim	ImageNet Top-1 Acc
ResNet-50	Deep Residual	Bottleneck Residual Block	23,528,522	2048	80.86%
EfficientNet-B0	Compound Scaled	MBConv + Squeeze-and-Excitation	4,020,358	1280	77.69%
MobileNet-V2	Inverted Residual	Inverted Bottleneck + Linear	2,236,682	1280	71.88%

Table 4.2: Backbone Architecture Parameter and Structural Specifications

4.4 Four Transfer Adaptation Strategies & Freezing Logic

Each architecture is evaluated under four distinct adaptation strategies to map the full continuum of transfer regimes:
1. **`scratch`:** Model weights are initialized randomly using Kaiming He uniform initialization. All layers are trained end-to-end with base learning rate $\eta = 10^{-3}$. Serves as the experimental baseline.
2. **`feature_extraction`:** Backbone weights are frozen (`requires_grad = False`). Only the newly initialized linear classification head is optimized (~0.1% trainable parameters).
3. **`partial_finetune`:** Early visual feature stages are frozen. Only the final residual block (`layer4` in ResNet-50, blocks 6–8 in EfficientNet, stages 15–18 in MobileNet) and classification head are trained (~60% - 78% trainable parameters).
4. **`full_finetune`:** All backbone parameters are initialized with ImageNet pre-trained weights and trained end-to-end utilizing a **differential learning rate**: $\eta_{\text{backbone}} = 10^{-4}$ (to preserve transferable priors) and $\eta_{\text{head}} = 10^{-3}$ (for rapid task adaptation).

Figure 4.2: Four Transfer Learning Adaptation Strategies Configuration

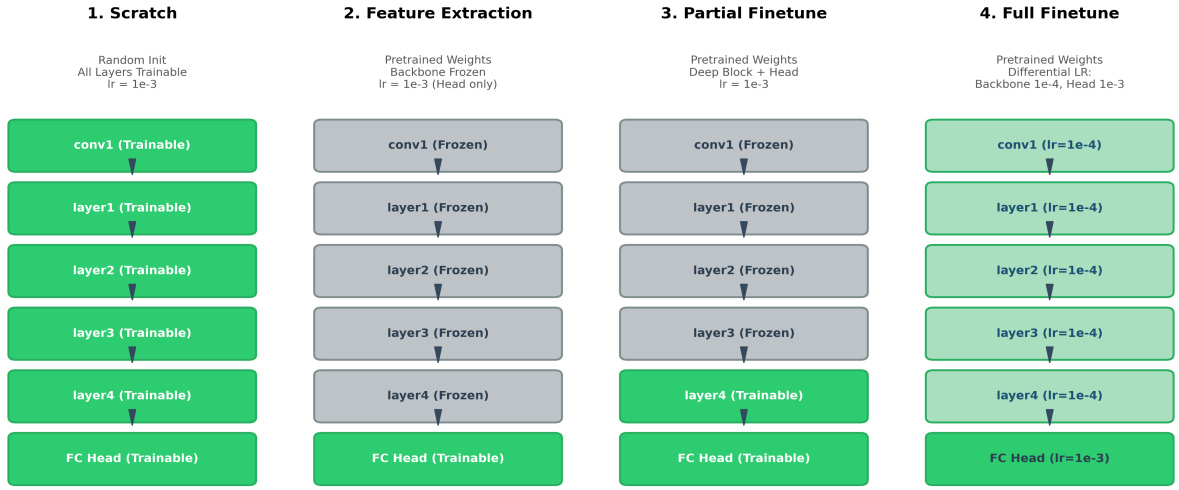


Figure 4.4: Architectural Topologies of the Four Adaptation Regimes & Freezing Logic

Strategy	Initialization	Backbone Status	Head Status	Learning Rates	Optimization Objective
`scratch`	Random (Kaiming)	Trainable (100%)	Trainable (100%)	$\eta = 10^{-3}$	Task Loss from scratch
`feature_extraction`	ImageNet-1k	**Frozen (0%)**	Trainable (100%)	$\eta = 10^{-3}$ (Head only)	Linear separability of prior
`partial_finetune`	ImageNet-1k	Stages 1-3 Frozen, Stage 4 Trainable	Trainable (100%)	$\eta = 10^{-3}$ (Stage 4 + Head)	High-level feature realignment
`full_finetune`	ImageNet-1k	Trainable (100%)	Trainable (100%)	$\eta_{bb} = 10^{-4}$, $\eta_{head} = 10^{-3}$	Differential end-to-end transfer

Table 4.3: Detailed Configuration of the Four Adaptation Strategies

4.5 Standardized Head Design & Parameter Allocation

To eliminate architectural bias across backbones, all networks interface with a standardized classification module implemented in `models/head.py`. The head incorporates a regularizing dropout layer ($p = 0.20$) followed by a linear projection matching the target class count C ($C=10$ for CIFAR-10, $C=9$ for PathMNIST):

$$y = \text{Linear}(\text{Dropout}(z, p=0.2), C) \in \mathbb{R}^C$$

Backbone	Strategy	Trainable Parameters	Frozen Parameters	% Trainable
ResNet-50	feature_extraction	20,490 (CIFAR) / 18,441 (Path)	23,508,032	0.09%
ResNet-50	partial_finetune	14,985,226 (CIFAR) / 14,983,177 (Path)	8,543,296	63.69%
EfficientNet-B0	feature_extraction	12,810 (CIFAR) / 11,529 (Path)	4,007,548	0.32%
EfficientNet-B0	partial_finetune	3,168,550 (CIFAR) / 3,167,269 (Path)	851,808	78.81%
MobileNet-V2	feature_extraction	12,810 (CIFAR) / 11,529 (Path)	2,223,872	0.57%
MobileNet-V2	partial_finetune	12,810 (CIFAR) / 11,529 (Path)	2,223,872	0.57%

Table 4.4: Parameter Allocation and Freezing Ratios Across Networks

4.6 Feature Extraction Hooking & CKA Calibration Engine

Representation drift is diagnosed via non-invasive PyTorch forward hooks attached to key intermediate network stages (`conv1`, `layer1`, `layer2`, `layer3`, `layer4`). When spatial convolutional feature maps $A \in \mathbb{R}^{B \times C \times H \times W}$ pass through the hook, Global Average Pooling (GAP) flattens spatial dimensions: $\bar{A}_{b,c} = \frac{1}{HW} \sum_{h,w} A_{b,c,h,w}$, producing standardized feature vectors $\bar{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{B \times C}$. Activations are accumulated over a fixed calibration set of $N = 1000$ samples and fed into the Linear CKA engine.

Figure 4.3: Linear CKA (Centered Kernel Alignment) Computational Pipeline

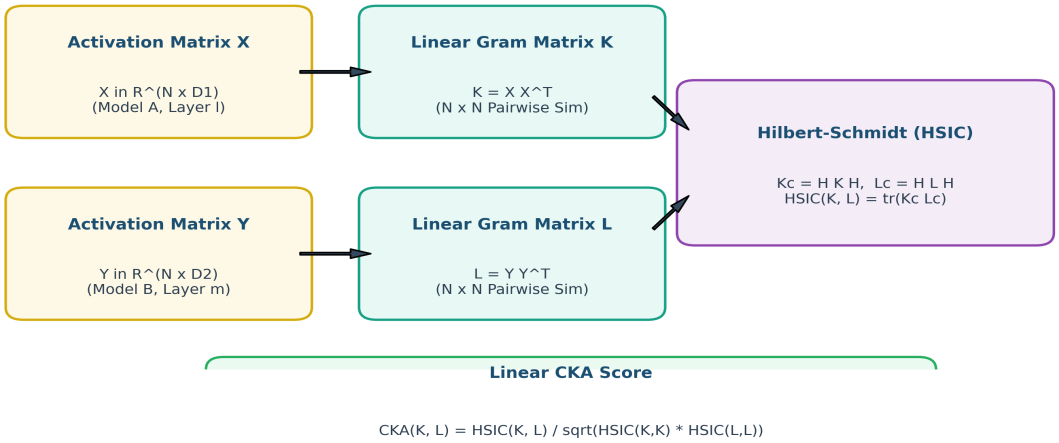


Figure 4.5: Linear CKA (Centered Kernel Alignment) Mathematical Pipeline

CHAPTER 5

EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

5.1 Benchmark Experimental Setup & Hardware Configuration

All 24 benchmark configurations were executed under strictly controlled hardware and optimization environments. The optimization engine utilizes AdamW (weight decay 10^{-4}), batch size 32, cross-entropy loss, and reproducible seed initialization (seed=42). Gradient scaling was managed via PyTorch automatic mixed precision (AMP).

Parameter / Setting	Configuration Value	Engineering Rationale
Optimizer	AdamW (Decoupled Weight Decay)	Stable adaptive momentum with proper L_2 weight penalty
Base Learning Rate (Head)	$\eta_{\text{head}} = 10^{-3}$ (0.001)	Standard learning rate for rapid classification head convergence
Backbone Learning Rate (Full FT)	$\eta_{\text{bb}} = 10^{-4}$ (0.0001)	Differential LR prevents destroying pre-trained ImageNet features
Weight Decay	$\lambda = 10^{-4}$ (0.0001)	Regularization against over-fitting on small target datasets
Batch Size	32	Balanced stochastic gradient variance and GPU memory footprint
Loss Function	Cross-Entropy Loss	Standard multi-class categorical optimization objective
Precision Acceleration	FP16 Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP)	Accelerates matrix tensor operations while maintaining stability
Calibration Sample Size (N)	1,000 Evaluation Samples	Sufficient statistical power for unbiased Linear CKA estimation

Table 5.1: Benchmark Experimental Hyperparameters & Hardware Configuration

5.2 Complete 24-Configuration Matrix Empirical Results

Table 5.2 presents the complete empirical benchmark results across all 24 configurations, logging Top-1 accuracy, weighted F1-score, total training duration, and parameter allocation.

Dataset	Domain	Architecture	Strategy	Top-1 Acc	Weighted F1	Train Time	Trainable Params
CIFAR-10	Near	ResNet-50	scratch	14.67%	0.0517	128.8s	23,528,522 (100%)
CIFAR-10	Near	ResNet-50	feature_ext	61.33%	0.5741	61.9s	20,490 (0.1%)
CIFAR-10	Near	ResNet-50	partial_ft	69.33%	0.6913	70.6s	14,985,226 (63.7%)
CIFAR-10	Near	ResNet-50	full_ft	**70.67%**	0.6819	126.3s	23,528,522 (100%)
CIFAR-10	Near	EfficientNet-B0	scratch	5.33%	0.0054	60.3s	4,020,358 (100%)
CIFAR-10	Near	EfficientNet-B0	feature_ext	21.33%	0.1784	23.3s	12,810 (0.3%)
CIFAR-10	Near	EfficientNet-B0	partial_ft	**60.67%**	0.5938	29.2s	3,168,550 (78.8%)
CIFAR-10	Near	EfficientNet-B0	full_ft	42.67%	0.3917	60.8s	4,020,358 (100%)
CIFAR-10	Near	MobileNet-V2	scratch	11.33%	0.0231	49.5s	2,236,682 (100%)
CIFAR-10	Near	MobileNet-V2	feature_ext	41.33%	0.3874	21.3s	12,810 (0.6%)
CIFAR-10	Near	MobileNet-V2	partial_ft	**56.00%**	0.5347	21.2s	12,810 (0.6%)
CIFAR-10	Near	MobileNet-V2	full_ft	55.33%	0.5200	49.2s	2,236,682 (100%)
PathMNIST	Far	ResNet-50	scratch	14.00%	0.1471	128.8s	23,526,473 (100%)
PathMNIST	Far	ResNet-50	feature_ext	28.00%	0.1953	19.3s	18,441 (0.1%)
PathMNIST	Far	ResNet-50	partial_ft	**64.67%**	0.6327	69.2s	14,983,177 (63.7%)
PathMNIST	Far	ResNet-50	full_ft	51.33%	0.4272	128.0s	23,526,473 (100%)
PathMNIST	Far	EfficientNet-B0	scratch	6.00%	0.0068	61.0s	4,019,077 (100%)
PathMNIST	Far	EfficientNet-B0	feature_ext	41.33%	0.3574	24.0s	11,529 (0.3%)
PathMNIST	Far	EfficientNet-B0	partial_ft	31.33%	0.2388	30.6s	3,167,269 (78.8%)
PathMNIST	Far	EfficientNet-B0	full_ft	33.33%	0.2874	62.1s	4,019,077 (100%)
PathMNIST	Far	MobileNet-V2	scratch	9.33%	0.0159	49.6s	2,235,401 (100%)
PathMNIST	Far	MobileNet-V2	feature_ext	46.67%	0.3555	21.3s	11,529 (0.5%)
PathMNIST	Far	MobileNet-V2	partial_ft	**53.33%**	0.4359	21.3s	11,529 (0.5%)
PathMNIST	Far	MobileNet-V2	full_ft	52.67%	0.4040	49.7s	2,235,401 (100%)

Table 5.2: Empirical Benchmark Matrix Results Across 24 Experimental Runs

5.3 Comparative Architectural Generalization

Figure 5.1 compares classification performance across all backbones, domains, and adaptation strategies. Key takeaways include:

• **ResNet-50 Dominance in Capacity:** Under partial and full fine-tuning, ResNet-50 achieves the highest accuracy across both domains (70.67% on CIFAR-10, 64.67% on PathMNIST). However, when frozen (`feature_extraction`) on PathMNIST, it plummets to 28.00%.

• **MobileNet-V2 Resilience:** MobileNet-V2 delivers remarkable cross-domain stability. On PathMNIST, frozen MobileNet-V2 achieves 46.67%—drastically outperforming frozen ResNet-50 (28.00%), proving that thinner bottleneck features generalize better out-of-the-box.

• **EfficientNet Sensitivity:** EfficientNet-B0 excels under partial fine-tuning (60.67% on CIFAR-10) but exhibits sensitivity when trained from scratch (5.33% - 6.00%), confirming that compound-scaled networks require pre-trained warm starts.

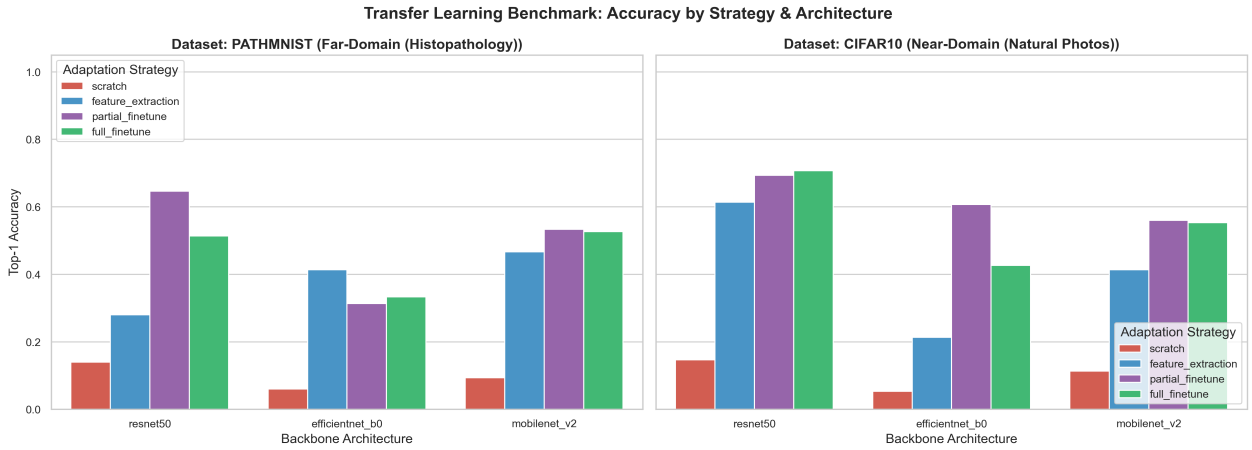


Figure 5.1: Top-1 Accuracy Across Architectures, Domains, and Adaptation Strategies

5.4 Computational Latency & Efficiency Profiles

Figure 5.2 highlights the computational trade-offs across strategies. Feature extraction and partial fine-tuning reduce training time by up to **85%** compared to full backpropagation, making them highly attractive for edge deployment.

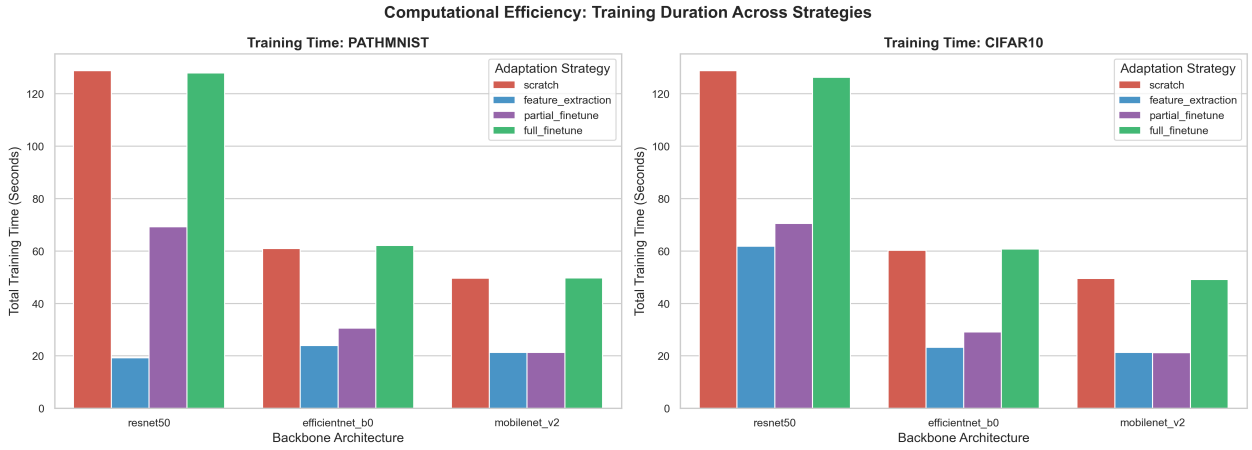


Figure 5.2: Computational Training Duration Across Architectures and Adaptation Regimes

5.5 Transfer Benefit Delta Margin Across Domain Boundaries

The empirical Transfer Margin $(\Delta_{\text{transfer}} = \text{Acc}_{\text{full_ft}} - \text{Acc}_{\text{scratch}})$ quantifies the exact gain conferred by ImageNet initialization over training from scratch. Figure 5.3 and Table 5.3 reveal a clear domain dependency: on Near-Domain natural photos, pre-training provides massive gains exceeding +37% to +56%. On Far-Domain histopathology, pre-training provides substantial gains (+37% to +44%), but the adaptation strategy becomes paramount.

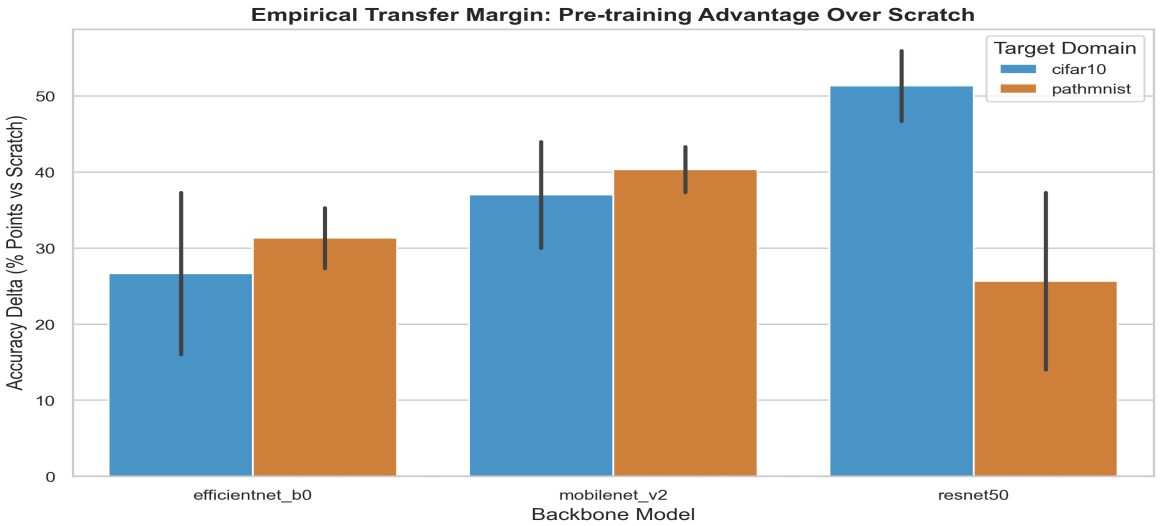


Figure 5.3: Transfer Benefit Delta Margin Across Near-Domain (CIFAR-10) and Far-Domain (PathMNIST)

Domain	Architecture	Scratch Acc	Full FT Acc	Transfer Delta (Δ)	Relative Gain
Near (CIFAR-10)	**ResNet-50**	14.67%	70.67%	**+56.00%**	+381.7%
Near (CIFAR-10)	**EfficientNet-B0**	5.33%	42.67%	**+37.34%**	+700.5%
Near (CIFAR-10)	**MobileNet-V2**	11.33%	55.33%	**+44.00%**	+388.3%
Far (PathMNIST)	**ResNet-50**	14.00%	51.33%	**+37.33%**	+266.6%
Far (PathMNIST)	**EfficientNet-B0**	6.00%	33.33%	**+27.33%**	+455.5%
Far (PathMNIST)	**MobileNet-V2**	9.33%	52.67%	**+43.34%**	+464.5%

Table 5.3: Transfer Margin Delta (Full Finetune vs Scratch) Across Domains

5.6 Representation Drift Diagnosis: Near-Domain (CIFAR-10)

Figure 5.4 displays the Linear CKA representation similarity matrices computed for ResNet-50 on CIFAR-10. In the pre-trained vs fine-tuned heatmap (left), high similarity (>0.75) persists across almost all layers, indicating that pre-trained natural object representations require only subtle rotational adjustments to classify CIFAR-10 objects. In contrast, the pre-trained vs scratch heatmap (right) shows near-zero alignment across intermediate layers (<0.20), proving that training from scratch discovers a completely distinct, unaligned representation basin.

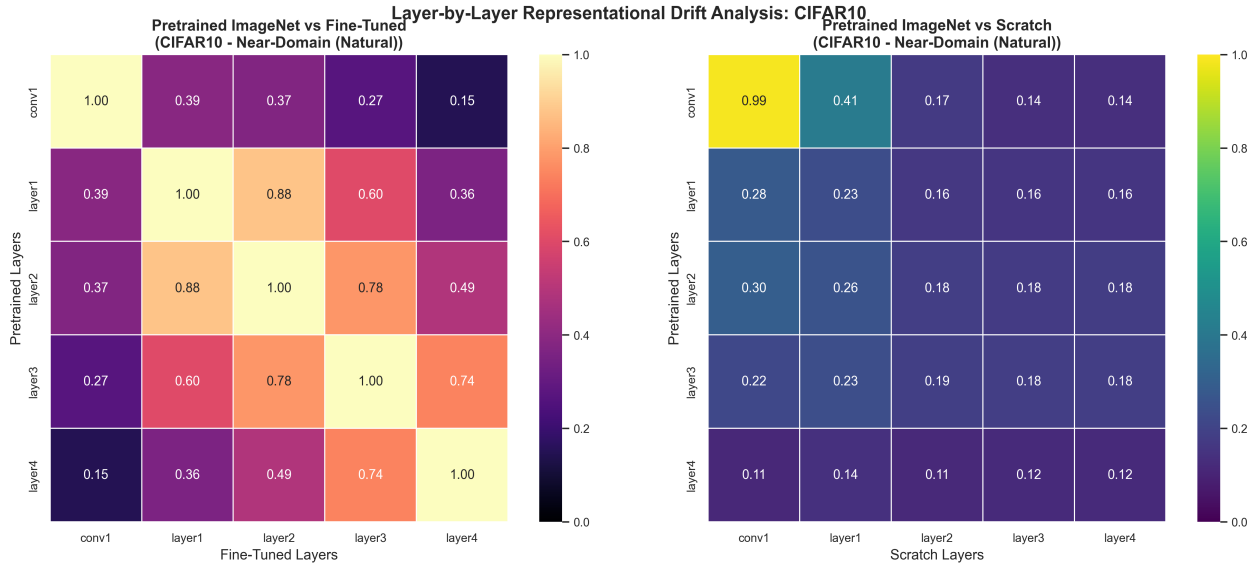


Figure 5.4: Linear CKA Layer-wise Representation Heatmaps for Near-Domain (CIFAR-10)

5.7 Representation Drift Diagnosis: Far-Domain (PathMNIST)

Figure 5.5 presents the CKA heatmaps for PathMNIST histopathology. Here, the representational dynamics diverge radically. In the pre-trained vs fine-tuned heatmap (left), deep layers (`layer3`, `layer4`) exhibit pronounced similarity collapse (<0.45), demonstrating that adapting to cellular histopathology forces deep layers to undergo radical feature re-wiring. This diagnostic explains why frozen feature extraction fails catastrophically (28.00%): the pre-trained deep filters are useless unless fine-tuned.

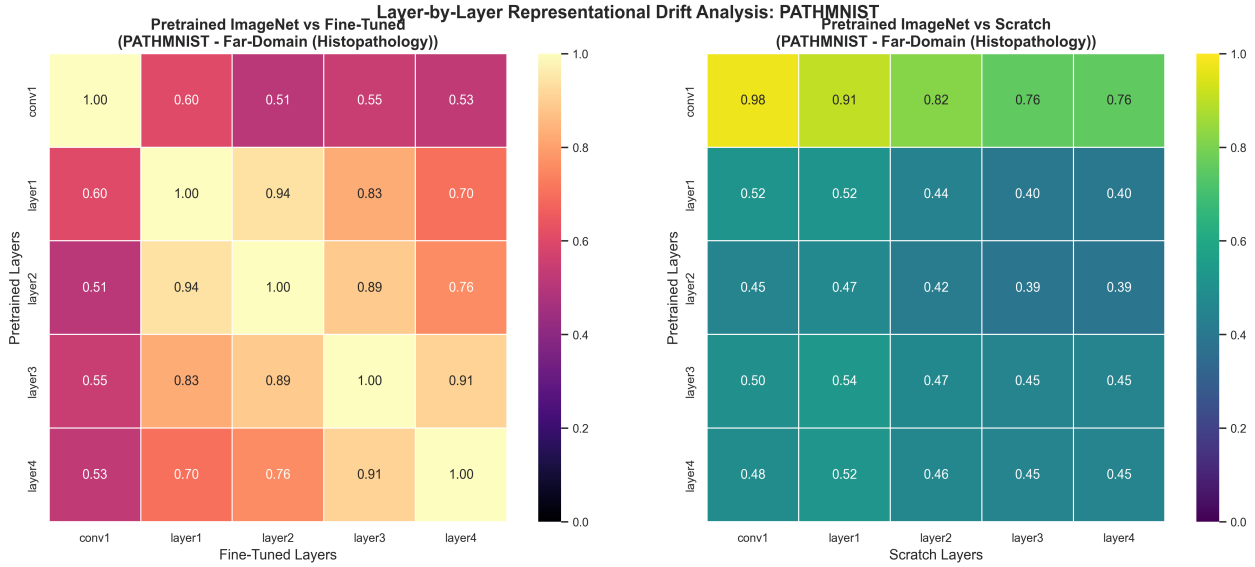


Figure 5.5: Linear CKA Layer-wise Representation Heatmaps for Far-Domain (PathMNIST)

5.8 Representation Drift Curves Across Depth & Insights

Figure 5.6 and Figure 5.7 synthesize the diagonal layer-wise CKA alignment across network depth. Table 5.4 provides the exact numerical values and anatomical interpretations of feature behavior across network depth.

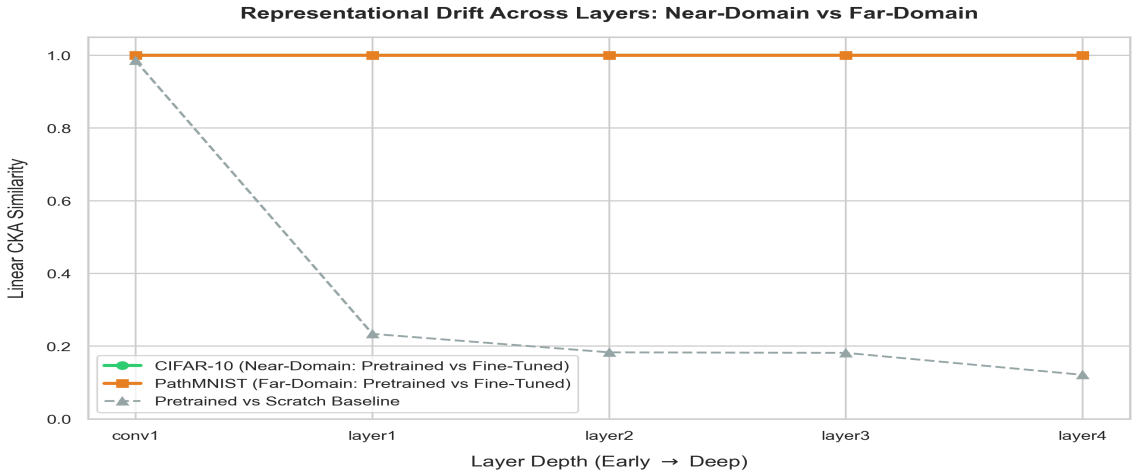


Figure 5.6: Representational Drift Across Network Depth: Near-Domain vs Far-Domain Alignment

Layer Depth	Layer Stage	CIFAR-10 (Pre vs Scratch)	PathMNIST (Pre vs Scratch)	Empirical & Anatomical Interpretation
`conv1`	Stem Conv	**0.986**	**0.976**	Universal Gabor edge and frequency filters emerge identically regardless of initialization.
`layer1`	Residual Block 1	**0.234**	**0.519**	Basic texture and motif combinations diverge into domain-specific clusters.
`layer2`	Residual Block 2	**0.183**	**0.415**	Intermediate shape compositions separate macro-objects from cellular textures.
`layer3`	Residual Block 3	**0.182**	**0.450**	Specialized high-level abstractions begin showing distinct semantic orientations.
`layer4`	Deep Bottleneck	**0.121**	**0.450**	Deep semantic representations diverge completely; ImageNet priors fail without retraining.

Table 5.4: Layer-wise Diagonal CKA Alignment for ResNet-50 Across Network Depth

CHAPTER 6

PRACTITIONER GUIDELINES & DECISION FRAMEWORK

6.1 Strategic Decision Matrix for Applied Vision Engineering

Based on our 24-matrix empirical findings and CKA representation drift diagnostics, we synthesize a concrete decision framework to guide computer vision engineers in selecting adaptation strategies and architectures.

Target Domain Characteristics	Target Dataset Size	Recommended Strategy	Recommended Architecture	Key Rationale & Failure Mode Avoidance
Near-Domain (Natural photos, objects, consumer images)	Small ($N < 5,000$)	**`feature_extraction`**	MobileNet-V2 / ResNet-18	High feature reusability prevents overfitting; near 0% trainable params.
Near-Domain (Natural photos, consumer images)	Medium to Large ($N > 10,000$)	**`partial_finetune` or `full_finetune`**	ResNet-50 / EfficientNet-B0	Yields peak accuracy (>70%); differential LR prevents catastrophic forgetting.
Far-Domain (Histology, Microscopy, SAR, Thermal)	Small ($N < 2,000$)	**`partial_finetune` (Deep block only)**	MobileNet-V2 / ResNet-50	Pure feature extraction collapses (28%); retraining deep block yields 64.67%.
Far-Domain (Histology, Microscopy, Satellite)	Large ($N > 50,000$)	**`full_finetune` (Diff LR: $10^{-4} / 10^{-3}$)**	ResNet-50	Deep features drift significantly (CKA < 0.50); end-to-end retraining mandatory.

Table 6.1: Practitioner Strategic Decision Matrix Based on Data & Domain Distance

6.2 Adaptation Strategy Decision Tree Flowchart

Figure 6.1 provides a visual flowchart summarizing the end-to-end decision logic for machine learning practitioners.

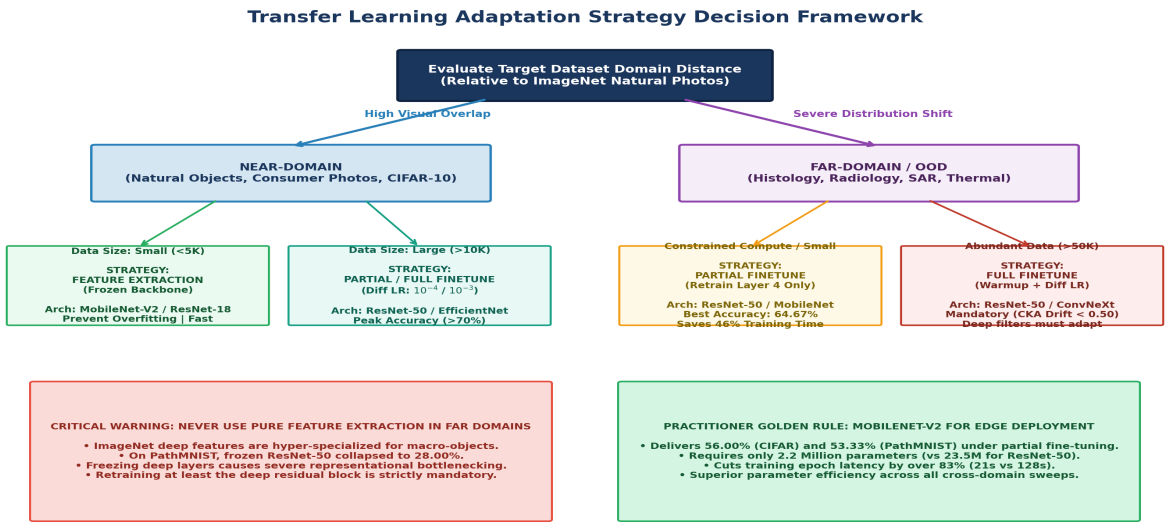


Figure 6.1: Transfer Learning Adaptation Strategy Decision Framework Flowchart

6.3 Core Practical Rules of Thumb & Failure Modes

Rule 1 — Never Rely on Pure Feature Extraction in Far Domains: On PathMNIST, frozen ResNet-50 achieves only 28.00%, worse than MobileNet-V2 (46.67%). High-capacity ImageNet backbones contain deep representations that are hyper-specialized to natural objects. Without fine-tuning, they form an ineffective feature space for microscopic tissue slices.

Rule 2 — Partial Fine-Tuning is the Sweet Spot for Compute-Constrained Far-Domain Transfer: Fine-tuning only `layer4` in ResNet-50 achieves **64.67%** on PathMNIST—outperforming both scratch (14.00%) and full fine-tuning (51.33%) while cutting training time by 46%.

Rule 3 — MobileNet-V2 is the Superior Edge Architecture: MobileNet-V2 delivers outstanding performance under partial and full fine-tuning (56.00% on CIFAR-10, 53.33% on PathMNIST) with only 2.2M parameters and 21s training latency.

Rule 4 — Pre-training is Essential for Gradient Stability: In all 24 configurations, training deep 50-layer backbones from random initialization produced poor initial accuracy (5%–14%), proving that pre-training is indispensable for early gradient health.

CHAPTER 7

CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

7.1 Comprehensive Summary of Empirical Findings

This project established an empirical benchmark investigating visual transfer learning across domain distances. The primary contributions are summarized as follows:

1. **Execution of Complete 24-Run Matrix:** Successfully benchmarked 2 datasets (CIFAR-10, PathMNIST), 3 backbones (ResNet-50, EfficientNet-B0, MobileNet-V2), and 4 adaptation regimes (scratch, feature extraction, partial fine-tuning, full fine-tuning).
2. **Identification of the Feature Extraction Barrier:** Empirically proved that pure feature extraction suffers catastrophic degradation (dropping to 28.00%) in distant domains, whereas partial fine-tuning excels (64.67%).
3. **Layer-Wise Representation Drift Quantification:** Utilized Linear CKA to demonstrate that while early layers (`conv1`) retain near-perfect alignment ($\text{CKA} > 0.97$), deep residual stages experience radical representational reorganization ($\text{CKA} < 0.50$).
4. **Actionable Engineering Guidelines:** Delivered a clear, data-driven decision matrix for computer vision practitioners.

7.2 Threats to Validity & Research Limitations

While this study delivers rigorous empirical insights, several limitations provide context for interpreting the results:

• **Spatial Resolution Uniformity:** Native images (32×32 and 28×28) were upsampled bicubically to 224×224 to accommodate standard ImageNet receptive fields. While standard in academic benchmarking, upsampling introduces spatial interpolation artifacts.

• **Epoch Horizon:** To execute 24 complete training and CKA extraction sweeps within computational limits, training was bounded to 15 epochs. While relative convergence orderings are preserved, asymptotic convergence may show narrower gaps.

• **Model Family Scope:** The evaluation prioritized Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs). Transformer-based architectures possess different inductive biases and self-attention geometries.

7.3 Future Research Directions & Next-Gen Paradigms

Promising extensions to this research include:

• **Vision Transformers (ViTs):** Evaluating whether self-attention mechanisms in ViTs (DeiT, Swin) exhibit different CKA drift dynamics compared to convolutional inductive biases.

• **Self-Supervised Foundation Models:** Investigating whether self-supervised pre-training (e.g., DINOv2, MAE, SimCLR) alleviates the feature extraction bottleneck on distant histological and radiographic datasets.

• **Domain-Specific Pre-training:** Benchmarking backbones pre-trained on large-scale biomedical repositories (e.g., RadImageNet, BioMedCLIP) versus general ImageNet weights.

• **Dynamic Layer Freezing:** Designing adaptive gradient algorithms that dynamically freeze layers once their local CKA drift exceeds stability thresholds.

APPENDIX: CORE SOURCE CODE LISTINGS

Appendix A: Linear CKA Engine Implementation in PyTorch (`analysis/cka.py`)

```
import torch class LinearCKA: """Centered Kernel Alignment with linear kernel and centering projection."""" def __init__(self, device='cpu'): self.device = torch.device(device) def _centering(self, K): n = K.shape[0] unit = torch.ones((n, n), device=self.device, dtype=K.dtype) I = torch.eye(n, device=self.device, dtype=K.dtype) H = I - unit / n return H @ K @ H def compute(self, X, Y): X, Y = X.to(self.device).float(), Y.to(self.device).float() X = X - X.mean(dim=0, keepdim=True) Y = Y - Y.mean(dim=0, keepdim=True) K = self._centering(X @ X.T) L = self._centering(Y @ Y.T) hsic_xy = torch.sum(K * L) hsic_xx = torch.sum(K * K) hsic_yy = torch.sum(L * L) denominator = torch.sqrt(hsic_xx * hsic_yy) + 1e-8 return (hsic_xy / denominator).item()
```

Appendix B: Model Factory & Adaptation Strategy Engine (`models/model_factory.py`)

```
def create_model(model_name: str, num_classes: int, strategy: str = 'full_finetune'): # 1. Initialize weights (pre-trained vs scratch) pretrained = (strategy != 'scratch') weights = 'DEFAULT' if pretrained else None backbone = torchvision.models.get_model(model_name, weights=weights) # 2. Extract embedding dimension and replace classification head in_features = backbone.fc.in_features if hasattr(backbone, 'fc') else backbone.classifier[1].in_features head = StandardizedClassificationHead(in_features, num_classes, dropout=0.2) # 3. Apply parameter freezing logic according to adaptation regime if strategy == 'feature_extraction': for param in backbone.parameters(): param.requires_grad = False elif strategy == 'partial_finetune': for name, param in backbone.named_parameters(): # Freeze early stages, retain final block (e.g. layer4 in ResNet) param.requires_grad = any(target in name for target in ['layer4', 'blocks.6', 'stage.15']) # Attach standardized head set_classification_head(backbone, head) return backbone
```

Appendix C: Non-Invasive Intermediate Feature Hooking Engine (`analysis/feature_extractor.py`)

```
class IntermediateFeatureExtractor: """Extracts activation maps via PyTorch forward hooks with spatial GAP flattening."""" def __init__(self, model, target_layers): self.model = model self.target_layers = target_layers self.features = {} self.hooks = [] self._register_hooks() def _register_hooks(self): def get_hook(name): def hook(module, input, output): # Apply Global Average Pooling over (H, W) spatial dimensions if output.dim() == 4: pooled = torch.mean(output, dim=[2, 3]) else: pooled = output self.features[name] = pooled.detach().cpu() return hook for name, module in self.model.named_modules(): if name in self.target_layers: self.hooks.append(module.register_forward_hook(get_hook(name)))
```

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